

Notes on the fonts, by Chuck Bigelow

The Go fonts are divided into two sets, Go proportional, which is sans-serif, and Go Mono, which is slab-serif.

Go proportional fonts

Sans-serif

Go proportional fonts are sans-serif, like several popular fonts for screen displays. There is some evidence that some sans-serif faces at small sizes and low resolutions on screens are slightly more legible than their seriffed counterparts, while at large sizes, there is not a significant difference in legibility between sans and seriffed faces, at least in the pair tested. [1] (The bracketed numbers refer to the references listed at the end of this article.)

Style

Go sans-serif fonts are "humanist" rather than "grotesque" in style. This is an historical distinction, not an aesthetic judgment. Widely used sans-serif fonts like Helvetica and Arial are called grotesque because an early 19th century sans-serif typeface was named "Grotesque," and the name became generic.

The shapes of modern grotesque fonts like Helvetica are sculpted, with smooth, assimilated forms.

Humanist sans-serifs are derived from Humanist handwriting and early fonts of the Italian Renaissance and still show subtle traces of pen-written calligraphy. There is some evidence that humanist fonts are more legible than grotesque fonts. [2]

Italics

Go proportional italics have the same width metrics as the roman fonts. Go italics are oblique versions of the romans, with one noticeable exception: the italic lowercase 'a' is redesigned as a cursive single-story form to harmonize with the bowl shapes of the b d g p q set, in which the upright forms also adapt well to slanting. The addition of cursive 'a' makes the italics appear more lively than a simply slanted roman. Some typographers believe that slanted roman sans-serif italics are preferable to truly "cursive" sans Italics, in part because of history and design. [3]